Documentation Style Guide (Portfolio Edition)

Adapted from original professional work. Organization-specific names, examples, and implementation details have been generalized.

Documentation principles

Start with user outcomes

Explain what readers can accomplish, not just which features exist.

Example: “Use customer-managed keys to control encryption keys for supported resources” rather than “The platform supports customer-managed keys.”

Provide context before instructions

Help readers understand why a task matters. Recommended sequence: Concept → Requirements → Procedure → Validation.

Write for clarity, not complexity

- Use short sentences, active voice, consistent terminology, and plain language where possible.
- Avoid unexplained acronyms, internal engineering terminology, and implementation details that do not affect the reader.

Document decisions, not just clicks

Explain meaningful choices: “Select an instance type based on workload performance and capacity requirements” is more useful than “Select an instance.”

Voice and tone

Documentation should be clear, helpful, professional, and consistent. Prefer direct instruction over conversational filler.

Writing standards

- Use active voice unless the action matters more than the actor.
- Use present tense to describe current behavior.
- Use direct, task-based language; avoid unnecessary passive constructions.

Content structure standards

Feature documentation

Overview → Benefits and use cases → Requirements → Limitations → Procedures → Verification → Troubleshooting (if applicable) → Related resources.

Procedure documentation

Before you begin (permissions, requirements, dependencies) → Numbered steps → Expected result → Next steps.

Release notes

Use a short, outcome-focused title. Explain what changed, why it matters, availability, requirements, and relevant documentation. Omit internal project names, unnecessary implementation details, and unsupported roadmap statements.

UI and visual documentation

- Use bold formatting for UI labels and reproduce action labels exactly.
- Use screenshots only when they support a specific task or concept; crop irrelevant details and remove identifying environment data.
- Avoid screenshots when the interface changes frequently or text is sufficient.
- Diagrams should prioritize relationships and data flow, use consistent labels, and omit unnecessary implementation detail.

Linking standards

Link to maintained conceptual and workflow documentation rather than duplicating explanations across multiple pages.

Technical review standards

Reviewers validate accuracy, prerequisites, unsupported scenarios, workflow completeness, and terminology. They don’t need to rewrite editorial style unless it affects meaning.